HOLLOW MANOR, PART II

The Killer Is Still in the House

A Flox mystery in three clues

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COLD OPEN

It worked on that machine.

On mine, the manor stays dark.

```
$ python3 server.py
⚠  RUNPOD_API_KEY is not set; the manor will stay dark…
```

02

MEET THE DETECTIVE

Flox: an environment you can hand to anyone.

OPEN SOURCE

One CLI

macOS and Linux. Laptops, CI, and servers.

THE CATALOG

100,000+

packages, from Python to Postgres to CUDA.

FLOXHUB

Shared

Push an environment. Your team activates it by name.

THE METHOD

A Flox environment is one file.

The *tools*, the *settings*, and the *services* a project needs.

Every machine that activates it gets the same thing.

04

HOW IT FEELS

Your machine, plus the project.

Hollow Manor's tools & settings	`flox activate`
Your shell, editor, dotfiles	unchanged
Your OS: macOS or Linux	unchanged

No container to build.

No VM.

Leave the project, and the layer goes with you.

UNDER THE FLOORBOARDS

Beneath Flox, there is Nix.

Every package is built in isolation, from inputs that are hashed.

Each build gets its own address. Versions never overwrite each other.

Flox gives you that, without learning the Nix language.

Where tonight's Python actually lives

```
/nix/store/
65p6ipj712fb5igr9w1h5k
5cb7bymj42-python3-3.12.13
```

Change any input, and the hash changes with it.

CLUE 1

Two Pythons. Three witnesses.

THE README

"3.9+"

Any Python will do, apparently.

THE DOCKERFILE

3.12

`FROM python:3.12-slim`

MY LAPTOP

Unknown.

Whatever it shipped with.

```
$ flox init
$ flox install python312
$ flox activate
```

07

What you asked for. What you got.

.flox/env/manifest.toml

```
[install]
python.pkg-path = "python312"
```

You write this.

.flox/env/manifest.lock

```
The exact build of
Python 3.12 for each
system, pinned.
```

Flox writes this.

Commit both.

CLUE 2

The key in the shell.

```
$ export RUNPOD_API_KEY=rpa_DEMO_not_real
$ history | grep rpa_
  512  export RUNPOD_API_KEY=rpa_DEMO_not_real
```

The README says `export`. Your shell history says *forever*.

09

THE RULE

Settings are shared. Secrets are loaded.

[vars]: committed, shared

```
[vars]
PORT = "8666"
DAILY_BUDGET_USD = "2"
```

[hook]: reads .env, never shared

```
[hook]
on-activate = '''
  set -a
  . "$FLOX_ENV_PROJECT/.env"
  set +a
'''
```

A secret never goes in the manifest.

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CLUE 3

The server nobody managed.

`python3 server.py` lives and dies with one terminal tab.

```
[services.manor]
command = 'python3 "$FLOX_ENV_PROJECT/server.py"'
```

```
$ flox activate --start-services
$ flox services logs manor --follow
```

THE ACCUSATION

A clean machine. One command.

```
$ git clone https://github.com/justincastilla/hollow-manor-mystery-II.git
$ cd hollow-manor-mystery-II
$ flox activate --start-services
```

No clone at all? `flox push`, then `flox activate -r`.

THE REVEAL

Case closed.

THE CLUE	THE CULPRIT	THE EVIDENCE
Two Pythons	No pinned toolchain	`flox install` + the lockfile
The key in the shell	Secrets with no home	`[hook]`, with settings in `[vars]`
The foreground process	A server nobody managed	`[services]`
"Works on my machine"	All of the above	`flox activate`

POSTSCRIPT

Your agents are new teammates, too.

THEY READ

One file

The manifest lists every tool, setting, and service. Nothing to guess.

THEY RUN

One command

`flox activate -- pytest` runs inside the environment, no prompt needed.

THEY CHANGE

Nothing else

An agent's `flox install` lands in the project, shows up in the diff, and rolls back with git.

EPILOGUE

The suspect was never the code.

It was everything around it.

flox.dev/docs

github.com/justincastilla/hollow-manor-mystery-II

Next: containers with flox containerize · composing environments with [include]